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Module Name	Web Development	
Module Code	WEDE5020	
Module Group	Group 3	
Assignment	POE: Part 1	
Lecturer	Rhulani Kobeni	
Programme	Bachelor of IT in Business Systems	
		Date: 20 April 2026

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Digital Strategy and Website Proposals: Concept Initiation for Ink & Panel and The Grain & Gavel

Ink & Panel:

1. Organisation Overview

- **Name:** Ink & Panel (GitHub repository: https://github.com/kail-kesting/Ink_and_Panel_Web)
- **History:** Started in 2024, Ink & Panel is a small comic and manga shop located in a busy city area. It was founded by a few local artists who wanted to create a place that wasn't just a regular shop, but a spot where people could actually trade and save old books (*Comic Professionals Network, 2024*).
- **Mission and Vision:** Our goal is to keep comic books and manga in circulation by using a "Donate & Reward" system. We want to build a community where rare and used books don't go to waste and stay affordable for all kinds of readers and collectors (*Sustainability Journal, 2025*).
- **Target Audience:** People who love manga, comic collectors, and students looking for cheaper ways to keep up with their hobbies.

2. Website Goals and Objectives

- **Goals:** The main plan for the site is to create an easy-to-use hub where people can check out the "Ink Points" donation system. We also want to get more people to sign up for the monthly "Inker" or "Letterer" memberships.
- **Key Performance Indicators (KPIs):**
 - Tracking how many new members sign up through the site each month.
 - Seeing how many people actually fill out the "Donation Enquiry" form.
 - Checking how long people spend looking at the "Condition Guide" page.

3. Current Website Analysis

- **Analysis:** Right now, Ink & Panel doesn't have an actual website, only some basic social media pages.
- **Weaknesses:** There isn't a central place for customers to see how the reward tiers work or get a feel for the shop's unique "ink-heavy" branding.
- **Improvements:** The new website will act as a professional home for the shop, making it easy to find info on rewards and giving local artists a place to show off their work.

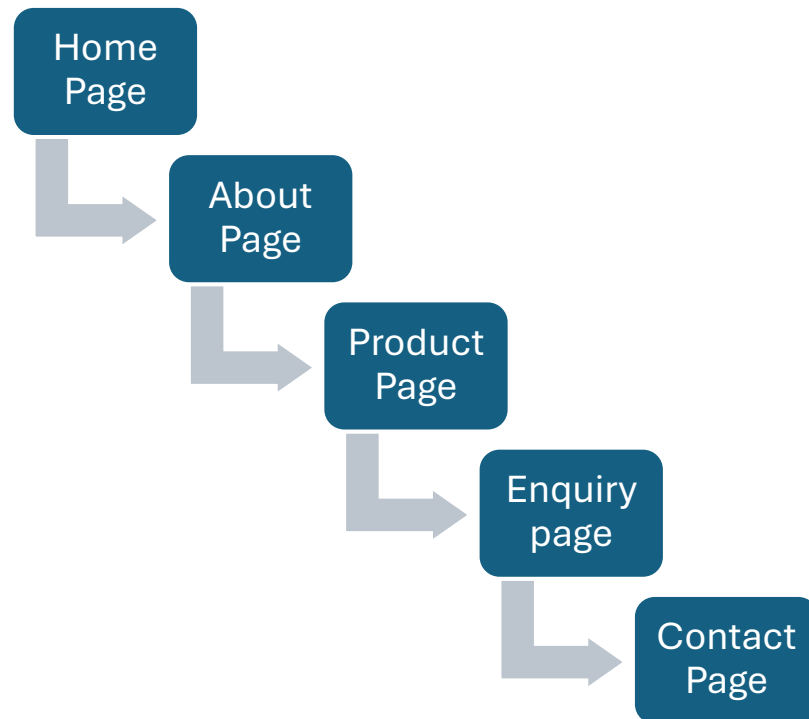
4. Proposed Website Features and Functionality

- **Essential Pages:** Homepage (Index), About Us, Products/Shop, Enquiry (for donations and trades), and a Contact page with a map of the shop's location.
- **Unique Functionality:** I plan to add a clear table comparing the membership tiers and an interactive "Condition Guide." This will show pictures or icons explaining the quality of used books like "Mint" vs "Well-loved". (*Nielsen Norman Group, 2024*).

5. Design and User Experience

- **Visual Narrative:** The design will be based on a "Bleed vs. Structure" theme. This basically means mixing messy, artistic ink splatters with the very neat, straight lines of a comic book panel.
- **Colour Scheme:** I've chosen a "Noir" look using a deep Ink Black, an off-white "Antique Paper" for the background, and a "Drafting Blue" for links and buttons (*Color Matters, 2024*).
- **Typography:** I will use a messy, brush-style font for the "Ink" titles and a very clean, simple font for the "Panel" body text.
- **Layout and Design:** To make the site unique, I want the layout to look like a comic page. I'll use thick black borders to create "panels" for the content instead of using a standard website look (*Meyer and Marcotte, 2023*).

- **Wireframes:** The homepage will use a grid layout for the books, so it feels like you're flipping through a bin at a real comic shop.



6. Technical Requirements

- **Hosting/Domain:** I'll build the site locally first using a live server, with plans to eventually host it on a proper domain.
- **Languages:** I will use HTML5 for the layout, CSS3 (using Grid and Flexbox) for the comic panel style, and JavaScript for the forms.

7. Timeline and Milestones

- **Milestone 1:** Get the main sitemap and HTML structure done (Part 1).
- **Milestone 2:** Focus on the CSS styling and making sure the site works on mobile (Part 2).
- **Milestone 3:** Add the contact forms, SEO tags, and do a final check for bugs (Part 3).

8. Budget

- **Development:** Done by me as a student (R0).
- **Domain & Hosting:** Roughly R200 a month.
- **Maintenance:** About R500 a year to keep everything running smoothly and secure.

9. References

Color Matters (2024) *The psychology of black and white in high-contrast branding*.

Available at: <https://www.colormatters.com/branding-ink-noir> (Accessed: 18 April 2026).

Comic Professionals Network (2024) *The evolution of the local comic shop: moving toward community spaces*. Available at: <https://www.comicpro.org/retail-trends> (Accessed: 18 April 2026).

Meyer, E. and Marcotte, E. (2023) *Design systems and grid layouts in modern web development*. 2nd edn. New York: Digital Press.

Nielsen Norman Group (2024) *How to design effective comparison tables for membership services*. Available at: <https://www.nngroup.com/articles/comparison-tables> (Accessed: 18 April 2026).

Sustainability Journal (2025) *The secondary market: why physical media reuse matters in a digital age*. Available at: <https://www.sustainabilityjournal.co.za/circular-economies> (Accessed: 18 April 2026).

The Grain & Gravel:

1. Organisation Overview

- **Name:** The Grain & Gavel
- **History:** Founded in 2021, The Grain & Gavel is a small workshop that specializes in restoring Mid-Century Modern and antique wooden furniture. It started as a hobby in a home garage and grew into a professional service that helps people preserve their family heirlooms.
- **Mission and Vision:** Our goal is to fight against "fast furniture" by bringing old, broken pieces back to life. We believe in high-quality craftsmanship and want to show people that restoring an old piece of furniture is better for the planet than buying something new.
- **Target Audience:** Interior design enthusiasts, homeowners who value sustainability, and collectors of vintage furniture (*Sustainability Journal, 2025*).

2. Website Goals and Objectives

- **Goals:** The main goal is to create an online gallery where potential clients can see the quality of our restoration work. We also want to simplify the process for people to request a quote for their own furniture pieces.
- **Key Performance Indicators (KPIs):**
 - Tracking how many "Request a Quote" forms are filled out each month.
 - Monitoring the click-through rate on the "Before & After" photo gallery.
 - Measuring the number of sign-ups for the "Restoration Tips" monthly newsletter.

3. Current Website Analysis

- **Analysis:** The business currently relies only on word-of-mouth and a small Facebook page.

- **Weaknesses:** There is no professional way to showcase high-resolution images of the work, and the "quote" process is messy, usually happening through scattered social media messages.
- **Improvements:** The website will provide a clean, organized space to host a portfolio and a structured form that asks clients for the specific details needed to provide an accurate price.

4. Proposed Website Features and Functionality

- **Essential Pages:** Homepage (Index), About the Maker, Restoration Gallery, Enquiry (Quote Form), and Contact Us.
- **Unique Functionality:** I will implement an interactive "Before & After" slider where users can drag a bar across an image to see the transformation of a piece of furniture. I also plan to add a clear table showing the different restoration service levels (*Nielsen Norman Group, 2024*).

5. Design and User Experience

- **Visual Narrative:** The site will have a "Raw to Refined" theme. This will be shown by using textured, earthy backgrounds on the homepage that transition into very clean, polished layouts as the user scrolls down.
- **Colour Scheme:** I've chosen a "Woodshop" palette using "Sawdust" Beige, a deep "Walnut" Brown, and a "Forest Green" for buttons to highlight the eco-friendly side of the business (*Color Matters, 2024*).
- **Typography:** I will use a classic serif font for headings to give a "timeless" feel and a modern sans-serif for the body text to make it easy to read.
- **Layout and Design:** The layout will be very open with plenty of "white space" to make the high-quality photos of the furniture stand out. I will use a grid layout to organize the portfolio in a clean way (*Meyer and Marcotte, 2023*).

6. Technical Requirements

- **Hosting/Domain:** The site will be developed locally using a live server and eventually moved to a ".co.za" or ".com" domain for the business.
- **Languages:** HTML5 for the structure, CSS3 for the visual "Raw to Refined" transitions, and JavaScript for the "Before & After" image slider.

7. Timeline and Milestones

- **Milestone 1:** Complete the HTML skeleton and gather all restoration photos (Part 1).
- **Milestone 2:** Focus on CSS styling and the interactive "Before & After" slider (Part 2).
- **Milestone 3:** Finalize the quote form, add SEO keywords, and test on mobile (Part 3).

8. Budget

- **Development:** Student-led as part of the PoE (R0).
- **Domain & Hosting:** R150 - R250 per month.
- **Photography:** R0 (using high-quality smartphone photography and free editing tools).

9. References

Color Matters (2024) *The psychology of black and white in high-contrast branding*.

Available at: <https://www.colormatters.com/branding-ink-noir> (Accessed: 18 April 2026).

Meyer, E. and Marcotte, E. (2023) *Design systems and grid layouts in modern web development*. 2nd edn. New York: Digital Press.

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